

# BUSINESS STARTUP CHECKLIST

## 1. ASSESSING YOUR OPPORTUNITY (WHAT DO YOU WANT?)

- ☐ Determine why you want to start a business
- ☐ Conduct a **SWOT** analysis to identify your strengths and weaknesses.
- ☐ Decide whether you want to provide a product or a service; build an online business or bricks and mortar.
- ☐ Assess how much capital you have to risk and how long it will last
- ☐ Determine if you want the business to be part-time or full-time.
- ☐ Discuss your plans with family members to ensure they are behind you.

## 2. COMMITTING TO YOUR BUSINESS

- ☐ Make a list of business ideas that fit your strengths and interests.
- ☐ Identify businesses that are having success today.
- ☐ Understand the problem(s) your business will solve.
- ☐ Define the market you want to pursue and your target customer.
- ☐ Validate your idea by talking to potential customers about it.
- ☐ Evaluate how customers solve this problem today, as well as what the competition offers.
- ☐ Create a quick financial plan, identifying costs and forecasted sales to see if your capital gets you to a profit.

## 3. SETTING UP YOUR BUSINESS

- ☐ Select your business name and search the internet to make sure it's not being used.
- ☐ Register a domain name and secure social media profiles for the company.
- ☐ Apply for an **EIN** with the IRS and local or state business licenses.
- ☐ Decide on a legal structure or business structure and incorporate: Corporation, LLC or Sole Proprietorship.
- ☐ Get your website up and running.
- ☐ Establish your company's accounting plan: hire an accountant, select an accounting system, and a fiscal year.
- ☐ Evaluate and select needed insurance policies for your business: liability, workers comp, or health insurance
- ☐ Open a business bank account and business credit card.
- ☐ Begin networking with pre-marketing materials such as business cards, brochures, or public relations.

#### 4. ENSURING SUFFICIENT FUNDS ARE AVAILABLE

- ☐ Estimate how long it will take for your business to acquire paying customers.
- ☐ Itemize your living expenses for the first year, at least, and assess where this will come from.
- ☐ Itemize how much capital is required to launch the business and project how long before profitability.
- ☐ From this, determine how many months of savings or investment you have to get to breakeven or profit.
- ☐ If outside investment is required beyond the founders' savings, complete a business plan.

#### 5. PLANNING FOR YOUR BUSINESS

- ☐ Write an **Executive Summary** after the other sections of the Business Plan are completed below.
- ☐ Complete a **Company Overview** that includes basic information and a summary of the management team.
- ☐ Write a **Product Description** section describing your products or services and what problems they solve.
- ☐ Prepare a **Market Analysis** section that describes the total market and your target market, specific segment needs, competitive offerings available, and any trends that will affect the analysis.
- ☐ Describe an **Operating Plan** for the business, such as operating hours, number of employees, key suppliers, or seasonal adjustments your business might need to adjust to.
- ☐ Create a **Marketing and Sales Plan** that includes a "Go To Market" or launch plan, pricing, how your business will generate leads, and close new business.
- ☐ Build a **Financial Plan** that shows a break-even analysis, projected profit and loss, and projected cash flows.

#### 6. SETTING UP TO OPERATE

- ☐ Find and secure a business location, even home offices need good design.
- ☐ Identify any staffing needs and the profile of employee or contractor that is best.
- ☐ Recruit, interview, hire, and train employees.
- ☐ Identify and set up any needed technology: **POS**, Email, Phones, **CRM**, Billing and Payment systems
- ☐ Ensure your technology systems are secure with your information or customer information.
- ☐ Depending on the business type, identify and partner with the right suppliers.

## 7. MARKETING AND LAUNCHING YOUR BUSINESS

- ☐ Develop and refine a brand for your company and its products or services.
- ☐ Create and fine tune an **Elevator Pitch** through conversations with anyone who will list.
- ☐ Begin distributing or displaying your marketing materials: shop signs, brochures, or banners.
- ☐ Online, initiate digital marketing through blogs, emails, or SEO strategies to drive traffic to your web site.
- ☐ Hire a salesperson or sales team.
- ☐ Let the local or regional press know you are opening.
- ☐ Utilize **Guerrilla Marketing** tactics to generate traffic.
- ☐ Organize an opening day.
- ☐ **Have fun!!**